those recovered from Sisupalgarh.[36] Either way, Dhauli could not have been located inside Tosali. However, if Tosali was indeed located at Sisupalgarh, Dhauli's rocks were in its immediate hinterland. This was a crucial hub in the Mauryan scheme of things in Kalinga. A prince was headquartered there, in the same way as at Suvarnagiri, Ujjayini, and Taxila. Many other segments of this eastern region were dotted with settlements, including Manamuda in the Boudh district which has yielded pottery with a close affinity to that of the Gangetic plains and Central India; and Asurgarh, a port town in Kalahandi district which was fortified and contemporary with Sisupalgarh.[37] However, only Tosali and Samapa find mention in Ashoka's epigraphs.

What of the place of the fateful battle? While it is likely that it was in the zone stretching from Jajpur to Ganjam, precisely where the Mauryan forces were actively resisted by the Kalingans remains unknown. Where one would like to locate the definitive military combat—whether near Bhubaneshwar and not far from Sisupalgarh and the Dhauli rocks, or much further south beyond Srikakulam—depends upon the route that one imagines Ashoka's forces used in their traverse from Pataliputra to Kalinga. One view is that the Mauryan troops took the same route that centuries later was followed by the Gupta king Samudragupta in his subcontinental campaign. Samudragupta is supposed to have arrived in Kalinga from Chhattisgarh.[38] Dilip Chakrabarti finds this an acceptable hypothesis because 'both these monarchs came from Pataliputra and both had Kalinga in their purview.'[39] The Gupta monarch's campaign, though, was qualitatively different from that of the Mauryan. Samudragupta was moving in a very determined fashion against the confederacy whose kingpin was the Pallava king of Kanchi. So, his line of movement across Dakshina Kosala and Ganjam-Srikakulam made eminent political sense. On the other hand, Ashoka's campaign was a far more circumscribed offensive, and for him, the Bhubaneshwar–Jajpur area was likely to have been strategically